

Haligric Research Integration Series

RUNES, NORSE GODS & THE PAGAN/WICCAN TRADITION

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Elder Futhark, the Nine Worlds, Odin, Thor, Freya, Wicca, and the Living Path

*"I know that I hung on the windswept tree for nine full nights,
wounded with a spear, and given to Odin — myself to myself —
on that tree of which no man knows from what roots it rises."*

— Havamal, The Sayings of the High One

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Introduction

The Living Alphabet and the Living Gods

There is something about carved letters and painted gods that speaks directly to the oldest layers of human consciousness — something about the idea that language is not merely a communication tool but a living force, and that the divine is not remote but local, personal, and intimately involved in the world of weather and war, love and death, craft and courage. This is the world of the runes, the Norse gods, and the broader pagan and Wiccan traditions that have carried these understandings into the modern era.

The runes are simultaneously an alphabet, a magical system, a philosophical teaching, and a divinatory tool — one of the most complete sacred symbol systems in the world, each of the twenty-four letters carrying layers of meaning developed over centuries of practice and contemplation. The Norse gods who inhabit the same cultural world as the runes are some of the most psychologically complex, morally ambiguous, and philosophically rich divine figures in any tradition — beings who pursue wisdom at enormous personal cost, who fight battles they know they will ultimately lose, and who regard courage in the face of inevitable doom as the highest human virtue.

Wicca — the modern witchcraft religion developed primarily in the mid-twentieth century — draws on pre-Christian European paganism, ceremonial magic, folklore, and nature spirituality to create a living practice that honors the divine as both masculine and feminine, understands magic as the conscious direction of natural energy, and organizes sacred time around the turning of the seasons. From an estimated 8,000 Wiccans in the United States in 1990, the tradition grew to approximately 340,000 practitioners by 2008 and reached 1 to 1.5 million Americans identifying as Wicca or Pagan by 2014 (Pew Research Center). In England and Wales, 73,737 people identified as Pagan in the 2021 census — an increase from 56,620 in 2011. Paganism is now the fourth largest religion in Scotland. In Iceland, the Ásatrúarfélagið (Norse Pagan association) reported 6,023 members in 2025, representing 1.55% of the national population. This guide gives all three — runes, Norse gods, and Wicca — the depth they deserve.

The Origins of Runic Writing

The runes are not merely an alphabet. In the Norse/Germanic understanding, they are not a human invention at all — they are cosmic forces that exist independently of human perception, that were discovered (not created) by Odin through an act of extreme sacrifice, and that carry within themselves the power to affect reality when properly understood and employed.

Historical Origins

Runic writing emerged among Germanic peoples of northern Europe around the 2nd century CE. The earliest confirmed runic inscriptions date from approximately 150-200 CE and are found on objects across Scandinavia, northern Germany, and the regions of Germanic migration. The script almost certainly derived from contact with Mediterranean alphabets — particularly the Old Italic scripts (including Latin and possibly the Etruscan or North Italic alphabets). The word rune derives from the Proto-Germanic *runo, related to Old Norse run — meaning secret, mystery, whispered counsel, or hidden wisdom. The rune is not first and foremost a letter — it is a secret, a mystery that reveals itself to those who have prepared themselves to receive it.

Odin's Sacrifice and the Mythic Origin

The Norse mythological account of the runes' origin is one of the most extraordinary passages in all of world mythology. In the Havamal (Sayings of the High One), Odin himself speaks of how he obtained the runes: "I know that I hung on the windswept tree for nine full nights, wounded with a spear, and given to Odin — myself to myself — on that tree of which no man knows from what roots it rises. They gave me no bread and no mead to drink. I peered downward, I took up the runes, screaming I took them, and then I fell back." Odin hangs on Yggdrasil, the World Tree, for nine nights — wounded, starving, without water, and without the help of any other being. This is an initiatory death: a voluntary descent into extremity in order to receive something that cannot be obtained any other way. At the moment of maximum suffering and surrender, the runes reveal themselves from the depths of the tree.

The Three Runic Alphabets

The Elder Futhark (named for its first six letters: F-U-Th-A-R-K) contains 24 runes and is the oldest complete system, in use from approximately 150-800 CE — the most widely used in modern runic practice and the system explored in depth in Part Two. The Younger Futhark (16 runes, dominant in Scandinavia from the Viking Age onward, c. 800-1100 CE) simplified the system. The Anglo-Saxon Futhorc (28-33 runes) expanded the Elder system for use in England and developed some of the richest surviving runic poetry.

The Elder Futhark

All 24 Runes in Full

The Elder Futhark divides into three groups of eight runes called aettir (singular aett — family or group). Each aett is associated with a divine patron and carries its own internal coherence of meaning.

First Aett — Freya's Eight (Fehu through Wunjo)

FEHU | *Cattle, Wealth, Mobile Energy*

Abundance, circulation, life force as tangible resource

Fehu is the first rune — the beginning — and its subject is wealth, specifically the kind that moves and circulates rather than sits static. In the Norse world, cattle were living wealth: they required care, they reproduced, they provided milk, meat, and hide. Fehu is not the wealth you hoard but the wealth you steward and circulate. Its deeper teaching is that life force (hamingja — the Norse concept of personal luck or energy) is like cattle: it must be managed, circulated, and directed with skill. When Fehu appears, it signals that energy and resources are available — the question is whether they are being wisely stewarded or squandered.

URUZ | *Aurochs, Primal Strength, Untamed Force*

Raw power, health, the wild that cannot be fully domesticated

The aurochs was the enormous wild ancestor of domestic cattle — massive, aggressive, and untameable. Uruz is the rune of primal, undifferentiated life force: the raw vitality that exists before it has been shaped into any specific form. Its shadow teaching concerns the danger of primal force that is never disciplined — enormous power without direction destroys as easily as it builds. Uruz's gift is access to the deep well of primal energy; its challenge is learning to work with it rather than being overwhelmed by it.

THURISAZ | *Giant/Thorn, Directed Force, Threshold*

Defensive power, the thorn that protects the rose, confrontation

Thurisaz is the rune of the thurses — the Giants, the ancient forces of chaos that predate the Norse gods — and also the thorn: the natural weapon of the rose, the protective force that grows precisely where it is needed. Thurisaz is not evil but it is dangerous: it represents directed, concentrated force that can destroy what needs to be destroyed and protect what needs to be protected. In divination, Thurisaz often signals a situation requiring direct confrontation rather than avoidance.

ANSUZ | *Odin's Rune, Divine Speech, Breath and Inspiration*

Communication, divine inspiration, the word as creative force

Ansuz is the rune of the Aesir and specifically of Odin in his aspect as the god of language, breath, and divine inspiration. Ond — the divine breath — is what Odin and his brothers breathed into the first humans to give them life. Ansuz is therefore the rune of divine communication: the moment when a message arrives from beyond ordinary thought, when a word or idea carries unusual power and clarity. It is the rune of the poet, the teacher, and the sage — those whose words carry life rather than merely information.

RAIDHO | *Riding, Journey, Right Order of Movement*

The path, pilgrimage, alignment with the correct direction

Raidho is the rune of the right journey — the movement that is aligned with one's true direction rather than movement for its own sake. It is also the rune of cosmic order and the rhythmic cycles that govern all movement: the wheel of the year, the path of the sun, the rhythm of day and night. Raidho asks: are you on the right road? Are you moving at the right pace?

KENAZ | *Torch, Fire of Craft, Controlled Illumination*

Creativity, technical skill, the inner fire of the craftworker

Kenaz is the torch — not the wild fire of a forest conflagration but the controlled, directed flame that illuminates a workshop and allows careful work to be done in the dark. It is the fire of craft: the rune of the smith, the weaver, the poet — anyone who transforms raw material through sustained, skilled application of creative fire. Kenaz is the rune of initiation (the initiatory fire that transforms the initiate) and of inner illumination: the light that allows you to see clearly what is actually in your own interior.

GEBO | *Gift, Sacred Exchange, Reciprocity*

The gift that creates relationship, generosity, sacred reciprocity

Gebo is the rune of the gift — and in the Norse world, gifts were never free. A gift creates a relationship of reciprocal obligation: the recipient is not diminished but bound in a web of mutual generosity that constitutes the fabric of human community. Gebo is the rune of sacred exchange: the understanding that all relationship — between humans, between humans and gods, between humans and the living world — is structured as a cycle of giving and receiving. Its shape is the X — two lines crossing, the intersection of two paths, the meeting point of two wills in mutual exchange.

WUNJO | *Joy, Belonging, the Harmony of Right Community*

Happiness, fellowship, the joy that arises from being in the right place

Wunjo is the rune of joy — but not the superficial happiness of getting what you wanted. Wunjo is the deep joy of belonging: the experience of being exactly where you are supposed to be, among the people you are supposed to be with, doing what you are meant to do. Wunjo signals alignment — between inner and outer, between self and community, between desire and reality. Its shadow is the false joy of conformity — belonging that requires the self to be suppressed.

Second Aett — Heimdall's Eight (Hagalaz through Sowilo)

HAGALAZ | *Hail, Disruption, Destructive Transformation*

The storm that clears, unavoidable disruption, the gift of destruction

Hagalaz is hail — the sudden storm that destroys what was growing, that arrives without warning and leaves devastation. It is the rune of unavoidable disruption: the crisis that cannot be prevented, only navigated. But hail melts into water — and the Norse saw in this a deeper pattern. Hagalaz is the seed-form of the nine runes of Heimdall's aett. Destruction contains within it the pattern of what will come after. The hailstorm is also rain; the devastation is also clearing.

NAUDHIZ | *Need, Necessity, the Fire of Friction*

Constraint, patience in difficulty, the power generated by resistance

Naudhiz is need — specifically the need-fire, the fire generated by friction rather than by a torch or hearth. Naudhiz is the rune of necessary constraint: the difficult conditions that, endured with patience and will, generate a power that comfort never could. It is also the rune of discernment — of knowing what you truly need versus what you merely want. Its teaching is that resistance is not simply an obstacle but often the very thing that produces the strength required for the next phase.

ISA | *Ice, Stillness, the Pause Before Action*

Stasis, concentration, the necessary freeze before breakthrough

Isa is ice — the complete stopping of all movement, the freezing of what was flowing. Isa teaches that not all pauses are failures: sometimes everything must come to a complete stop before the next movement can begin. It is the rune of concentrated mental focus — ice as the purest form of water, the essential distilled — and of the necessary rest before the next creative surge.

JERA | *Year, Harvest, the Cyclical Return of Right Timing*

Patience, the long view, the harvest that comes to those who have prepared

Jera is the rune of the year in its complete cycle — sowing, tending, harvesting, resting, sowing again. It is the rune of right timing: the recognition that natural processes cannot be rushed, that the harvest arrives when the harvest arrives, and that the farmer who attempts to reap before the grain is ripe destroys what they hoped to gather. Jera honors the reality that causes have effects at their own pace, and that wisdom consists partly in knowing which season you are actually in.

EIHWAZ | *Yew Tree, the Axis of Life and Death, Endurance*

The world axis, resilience through both worlds, death as passage not ending

The yew tree is the most ancient of European trees — some specimens are over 4,000 years old — and contains both deadly poison and life-preserving medicine within the same bark. Eihwaz is the rune of the world axis — the hidden center of Yggdrasil itself — and of the capacity to stand between worlds, to move through death and not be annihilated by it. It is the rune of the shaman, the death-walker, the one who can go where others cannot and return with knowledge.

PERTHRO | *Lot Cup, Chance, the Mystery of Fate*

The unknowable, the hidden, what is cast to chance

Perthro is among the most mysterious runes — its original meaning is genuinely debated, and that mystery is itself the teaching. Most interpretations associate it with the lot cup — the vessel of chance and fate. Perthro is what is hidden, what is cast, what is determined by forces beyond personal control. It is the rune of *wyrd* (the Norse concept of fate as an interwoven web of causes and consequences) and of the womb — the hidden place from which things emerge.

ALGIZ | *Elk-Sedge, Divine Protection, the Opened Hand*

Sanctuary, connection to the higher self, protective reach toward the divine

Algiz is the rune of protection — specifically the protection that comes from genuine connection to the divine and from living in alignment with one's higher self. Its shape is the upward-reaching form of a human being with arms raised: the gesture of prayer, of openness, of reaching toward what is above. Algiz teaches that genuine protection comes not from walls and weapons alone but from the clarity of conscience and the strength of spiritual connection.

SOWILO | *Sun, Solar Victory, Clarity and Life Force*

The guiding sun, will to overcome, the light that dissolves shadow

Sowilo is the sun — the guiding star that navigates ships through fog and darkness, the life-giving warmth that makes all growth possible, the clarity that dissolves confusion. It is the rune of solar victory: not the violent triumph of battle but the steady, inevitable victory of light over darkness when the sun rises. Sowilo is the rune of wholeness — the completed self that illuminates without extinguishing others.

Third Aett — Tyr's Eight (Tiwaz through Othala)

TIWAZ | *Tyr, Justice, Sacrificial Courage*

Right action regardless of cost, the warrior's integrity, sacred law

Tiwaz is the rune of Tyr — the one-handed god of justice who placed his hand in the mouth of the great wolf Fenrir as a pledge so that the other gods could bind him, knowing that when Fenrir discovered the binding was permanent, he would bite off the hand. Tyr gave his hand willingly so that justice could prevail. Tiwaz is therefore the rune of sacrificial courage — the willingness to pay the personal cost of doing what is right. It is associated with legal proceedings, righteous battle, and the kind of leadership that places principle above personal advantage.

BERKANO | *Birch, Birth, the Nurturing Container*

New beginnings, nurturing, the sacred feminine in her generative aspect

Berkano is the birch tree — the first tree to colonize cleared ground, the tree of new beginnings, associated with the goddess in her nurturing, birth-giving aspect. Berkano is the rune of birth in the broadest sense: the birth of children, of projects, of new phases of life. It is the great nurturing container — the womb, the nest, the protected space in which new life can grow before it is strong enough to face the world.

EHWAZ | *Horse, Partnership, the Trust Between Rider and Mount*

Sacred partnership, trust in relationship, harmonious movement together

Ehwaz is the horse — specifically the relationship between horse and rider. In the Norse world, the horse was the most sacred animal: it was sacrificed at the greatest rituals, associated with divine figures (Odin's eight-legged horse Sleipnir is the greatest horse in all the worlds), and understood as a partner rather than merely a vehicle. Ehwaz is the rune of sacred partnership: the trust, communication, and mutual attunement that makes two beings move as one.

MANNAZ | *Human Being, the Mutual Self, Human Consciousness*

The fully realized human, interconnectedness, self-knowledge

Mannaz is the rune of the human being — specifically the human in relationship to other humans and to the divine. Its shape is two Wunjo runes facing each other — two joys meeting — suggesting that the fully realized human is understood in terms of reciprocal relationship rather than isolated individuality. Mannaz is the rune of self-knowledge in the deepest sense: not narcissistic self-focus but the ability to see oneself clearly, including one's shadow.

LAGUZ | *Water, the Unconscious, Flow and Intuition*

The depths of feeling, psychic sensitivity, going with the current

Laguz is water — specifically the deep water of lakes, of the unconscious mind, of the sea of collective memory and ancestral knowledge. Laguz is the rune of flow, of intuition, of psychic sensitivity — the capacity to receive what is below the surface of conscious thought. It is associated with the healing arts, with dreams, and with the fluid, receptive mode of consciousness. Its challenge is dissolution — losing oneself in the depths rather than receiving from them and returning.

INGWAZ | *Ing/Freyr, Seed, Completion Before New Cycle*

The seed held in potential, quiet completion, the power of gestation

Ingwaz is the rune of Ing — an ancient Germanic deity later identified with Freyr, god of fertility and abundance. Its shape is the diamond or square: the compressed, contained form that holds maximum potential within minimum space — the seed. Ingwaz is the rune of completion in the sense of things coming to their proper conclusion before a new cycle begins. Its teaching: honor the completion before rushing to the next beginning.

DAGAZ | *Day, the Breakthrough Moment, Paradox Resolved*

The liminal threshold of dawn, the moment of transformation, breakthrough

Dagaz is the rune of the day — specifically the moment of dawn, the threshold between night and day, darkness and light. Its shape is the hourglass or butterfly: two triangles meeting at their points — the moment of balance, the instant of crossing from one state to another. Dagaz is the rune of breakthrough: the moment when what had been impossible suddenly becomes possible. It is also the rune of paradox — holding two opposites simultaneously until they resolve into a higher unity. Dagaz cannot be reversed: dawn always comes.

OTHALA | *Ancestral Home, Inheritance, Sacred Land*

The ancestral legacy, what is truly yours, the land that belongs to the self

Othala is the final rune of the Elder Futhark — and it is the rune of home, ancestral inheritance, and the sacred land that belongs to a people across generations. In the ancient Germanic world, the ancestral estate (the odal) was inalienable — it could not be sold but passed only within the family. Othala is what is truly, inalienably yours: your ancestral gifts, your genetic and spiritual inheritance, your people, your land. Its teaching: know what you have inherited, honor it, and transmit it wisely.

Rune Magic

Casting, Bindrunes, and Galdr

The runes were not merely written — they were used. The Norse and Germanic peoples employed runes in three primary magical modes: as inscribed charms (carved onto objects, weapons, amulets, and memorial stones), as divinatory tools (cast or drawn to reveal hidden patterns), and as vibrational invocations (chanted aloud in a practice called galdr).

RUNIC INSCRIPTION: The most ancient use of runes — carving specific runes or runic combinations into wood, bone, metal, or stone to imbue an object with that rune's energy. Weapons were inscribed for victory, amulets for protection, memorial stones to honor the dead and bind their memory to the world of the living. The act of carving was understood as an act of will: the practitioner (the runester or vitki) was channeling the rune's power into physical matter through the focused combination of their intention and the rune's inherent force.

BINDRUNES: A bindrune is the deliberate overlapping or combining of two or more runic staves into a single composite symbol, creating a concentrated talisman that carries multiple runic energies in unified form. The most famous historical bindrune is the Helm of Awe (Aegishjalmur): a wheel of eight Algiz runes pointing outward from a center, used as a symbol of invincibility.

GALDR — THE SUNG RUNE: Galdr (from the Old Norse verb gala — to sing, to crow, to chant) is the practice of chanting or singing the runes aloud. The sound of the rune's name, extended and projected with focused intention, was understood to activate and amplify the rune's power in the practitioner's body and energy field. The figure of the galdrowoman (galdrakona) appears repeatedly in the sagas as a practitioner of sung magical power.

RUNIC DIVINATION: In contemporary practice, runic divination most commonly involves drawing runes from a bag and reading their messages for the situation at hand. The practitioner formulates a question, draws one or more runes with intention, and interprets the rune's meaning in context — including whether the rune is upright or reversed (potentially indicating blocked or shadow aspects of the rune's teaching).

Norse Cosmology

Yggdrasil and the Nine Worlds

Norse cosmology is organized around Yggdrasil — the World Tree, an immense ash that grows at the center of all existence and whose branches and roots connect all the nine worlds. Yggdrasil has three massive roots extending to three cosmic wells: the first to Asgard and the Well of Urd (where the Norns weave the destinies of gods and humans); the second to Jotunheim and Mimir's Well (where Odin sacrificed his eye for wisdom); the third to Niflheim and Hvergelmir (the roaring cauldron from which all rivers spring). The tree is constantly under threat and constantly renewed.

The Nine Worlds

ASGARD: The realm of the Aesir gods — Odin, Thor, Frigg, Tyr, Baldr, and the others. Connected to Midgard by the rainbow bridge Bifrost, guarded by Heimdall.

MIDGARD: The Middle World — the realm of human beings, encircled by the great Midgard Serpent Jormungandr who bites its own tail in the outer ocean. Created from the body of the giant Ymir, slain by Odin and his brothers.

JOTUNHEIM: The realm of the Jotnar (Giants) — not evil but primordial, representing the untamed forces of nature that predate and surround the ordered cosmos of the gods. The Giants are simultaneously the gods' enemies, their in-laws, and their predecessors.

VANAHEIM: The realm of the Vanir — the other family of Norse gods, associated with fertility, magic (seidr), and the natural world. After a war between the Aesir and Vanir, a peace was made and key Vanir (Freyr, Freya, Njord) came to live in Asgard.

ALFHEIM: The realm of the Light Elves — luminous beings associated with creativity, light, and the natural world. Given to Freyr as a gift at his birth.

SVARTALFHEIM / NIDAVELLIR: The realm of the Dwarves — master craftworkers who created the greatest treasures of the gods: Thor's hammer Mjolnir, Odin's spear Gungnir, Freya's necklace Brisingamen, Gleipnir (the magical ribbon that binds Fenrir).

NIFLHEIM: The primordial realm of ice, cold, and mist — one of the two cosmic forces (fire being the other) whose interaction in the void of Ginnungagap created the first being, Ymir.

MUSPELHEIM: The primordial realm of fire. Ruled by the fire giant Surtr, who will ultimately destroy the world at Ragnarok.

HELHEIM: The realm of the dead — those who die of illness, old age, or circumstances other than glorious battle. Ruled by Hel (daughter of Loki), a being who is half living and half dead.

The Norse Pantheon

The Aesir and Vanir Gods

The Norse divine world is inhabited by two families of gods — the Aesir and the Vanir — plus the giants, the elves, the dwarves, and numerous other beings. The Aesir and Vanir were once at war; their peace brought the two families into alliance, and the combined pantheon of Norse mythology emerged from that synthesis. The Aesir tend toward governance, wisdom, and cosmic order; the Vanir toward fertility, magic, and the natural world.

The Aesir (residing in Asgard) include Odin (Allfather, god of wisdom, war, magic, and death), Thor (thunder, strength, protection of Midgard), Frigg (Odin's wife, goddess of marriage, motherhood, and foresight), Tyr (justice, sacrifice, sacred law), Baldr (beauty, light, the beloved one), Heimdall (guardian of Bifrost, divine watchman), Loki (the trickster, agent of both disruption and necessary change), Idun (keeper of the golden apples of immortality), and Bragi (poetry and eloquence). The primary Vanir who join Asgard after the Aesir-Vanir war are Freyr (abundance, sunshine, rain, fertility), Freya (love, war, magic, and death — who receives half of all who die in battle), and Njord (the sea, fishing, and favorable winds for sailors).

Odin

The Allfather and the Seeker

Odin (Old Norse: Óðinn; from óðr — fury, inspiration, the divine madness of the poet and the warrior) is the most complex figure in Norse mythology and one of the most complex divine figures in world religion. He is simultaneously the father of the gods and a relentless seeker who will sacrifice anything — including himself — to obtain greater knowledge and wisdom.

Odin is not the comfortable, all-powerful divine patriarch of many traditions. He is old, one-eyed (having sacrificed his eye to Mimir's Well for wisdom), and frequently goes in disguise among humans as a wandering old man in a wide-brimmed hat and cloak. He selects the bravest of the slain for Valhalla not because he values death but because he is assembling an army for Ragnarok, the final battle at the end of the world.

Odin knows his own fate. He knows that at Ragnarok, the great wolf Fenrir will swallow him. He has seen this in his visions and has done nothing to prevent it — because Ragnarok is *wyrd* (fate, destiny, the inevitable consequence of all that has gone before) and cannot be prevented. What Odin can do is prepare, gather wisdom, and ensure that the pattern of excellence that his cosmos has generated survives in some form past the end.

Odin's Sacrifices for Wisdom

The great signature of Odin's character is his willingness to pay enormous personal cost for wisdom. He hangs on Yggdrasil for nine nights to receive the runes. He sacrifices his eye to Mimir's Well. He undergoes many deaths and resurrections in his constant wanderings. He drinks from the mead of poetry (Odroyd — "the stirrer of inspiration"), obtained at great cost and shared generously with gods and humans alike. Odin is the patron of poets, skalds, runesters, warriors, wanderers, and all those who pay the personal price of genuine knowledge.

Odin travels with two ravens, Huginn (Thought) and Muninn (Memory), who fly across all the nine worlds each day and return to Odin's shoulders to whisper what they have seen. He also keeps two wolves, Geri and Freki, to whom he gives all the meat set before him — Odin himself sustains on wine alone. The ravens and wolves are extensions of his own cognitive faculties: Thought and Memory are what he sends into the world to gather knowledge; the wolves are his warrior nature given animal form.

Thor, Freya, Loki, and the Major Deities

THOR — God of Thunder, Protector of Midgard, Divine Strength

Thor (Old Norse: Þórr) is the most beloved of the Norse gods in the ancient world — the protector of humanity, the deity most commonly invoked by ordinary people, whose name (via Germanic Donar) gives us Thursday. Where Odin is the god of the elite — kings, warriors, skalds, shamans — Thor is the god of the common person. He is enormously strong, possesses Mjolnir (his hammer, the most powerful weapon in the nine worlds), wears iron gloves and a belt of power, and travels in a chariot drawn by two goats. Thor's primary work is the protection of Midgard from the giants — genuinely heroic work. Without Thor holding the boundaries of the human world against the chaos of Jotunheim, human civilization would not survive.

FREYA — Goddess of Love, Magic, War, and the Dead

Freya (Old Norse: Freyja, "Lady") is simultaneously the goddess of love and beauty, the greatest magical practitioner among the gods, a war goddess who receives half of all battle-slain, and the keeper of Sessrumnir — her hall in Folkvangr. She is the primary practitioner of seidr — the Norse form of magical working that involves trance states, shape-shifting, and the ability to weave fate. She taught seidr to Odin himself. Freya travels in a chariot drawn by cats, wears the necklace Brisingamen (obtained at great cost), and owns a feathered cloak that allows flight and shape-shifting. Freya holds more power than any other Norse deity except Odin himself — and she is rarely given the central theological importance she deserves.

LOKI — The Trickster, Agent of Change, the Fire That Shapes

Loki (his name possibly connected to logi — fire) is the most misunderstood figure in Norse mythology, particularly in contemporary Western culture which tends to flatten him into a simple villain. Loki is the trickster: the agent of disruption, unexpected change, creative solutions to impossible problems, and the consequences of cleverness without wisdom. He is not evil — he is complex in the way fire is complex: essential, creative, dangerous, and impossible to permanently control. Loki helps the gods more often than he harms them: he obtains Mjolnir for Thor, recovers Idunn's apples, assists in the building of Asgard's walls. His crimes — the killing of Baldr, his role in triggering Ragnarok — are the consequences of cleverness that finally outran its own wisdom.

FRIGG — Allmother, Goddess of Marriage and Foresight

Frigg is Odin's wife and the Allmother — the queen of Asgard and the patron of marriage, domesticity, motherhood, and the wisdom of the household. She is also a seeress: she knows the fate of all beings but, unlike Odin, she does not speak of what she knows. Frigg's silence is itself a teaching: some knowledge is not meant to be shared, some truths are honored by holding rather than broadcasting. She is most famous for her failed attempt to protect her son Baldr from death — extracting oaths from every being and every object not to harm him, failing only to extract the oath from mistletoe (which she considered too young and small to matter). Loki discovered this and engineered Baldr's death.

BALDR — God of Light, Beauty, and the Promise of Renewal

Baldr (meaning "bold" or "lord") is the most beloved of the Aesir — beautiful, radiant, kind, and invulnerable to almost everything in existence. His death at the hands of his blind brother Hodr (guided by Loki with the mistletoe) is the pivotal tragedy of Norse mythology: the death that cannot be undone, that sends the entire cosmos into mourning, that begins the sequence leading to Ragnarok. But Baldr is prophesied to return after Ragnarok, in the renewed world that follows the ending of the current cycle. Baldr is the Norse promise that what is most beautiful and most loved is not permanently destroyed — it waits beyond the ending.

Fate, the Norns, and the Web of Wyrd

The Norse understanding of fate is one of the most philosophically sophisticated in any tradition — and one of the most commonly misunderstood. Norse fate is not a predetermination that removes human agency. It is a web of woven consequences: the inevitable result of all causes that have gone before, within which new choices are always being made that will determine what comes after.

The Three Norns

At the base of Yggdrasil, beside the Well of Urd, dwell the three Norns: Urd (What Has Been / What Has Become), Verdandi (What Is Becoming / the Present), and Skuld (What Shall Be / Debt / That Which Must Happen). Together they weave the fate of gods and humans — carving their determinations into the wood of Yggdrasil and watering the tree daily from the sacred well. They are older than the gods themselves and answer to no authority above their own. Even Odin cannot override the Norns.

Wyrd — The Web of Fate

Wyrd (Old English; Old Norse: Urðr) gives us the modern English word "weird" — which originally meant "fate, destiny, what has happened." The wyrd is the web of all actions and consequences, past and present, that determines the field of future possibilities. Every being has a wyrd — not a fixed script but a pattern of tendencies and consequences that their past choices and their ancestors' choices have woven into their life's field. The skilled practitioner (the runester, the volva, the seeress) can read the wyrd — can perceive the pattern of what has been woven — and advise accordingly.

The Norse Warrior's Response to Fate

Knowing that fate cannot be avoided, the Norse response was not despair but magnification: if the outcome is determined, then the quality with which you meet it is everything. The warrior who faces death bravely adds to the web's beauty even as they are consumed by it. The recognition of fate in Norse tradition is not fatalism — it is the complete commitment to how you face what comes, since that is the dimension of experience that genuinely remains in your hands.

Norse Afterlife

Valhalla, Hel, and the Soul

VALHALLA — The Hall of the Slain: Reserved for those who die in battle and are chosen by the Valkyries to join Odin's einherjar — his army of the honored dead who train all day in glorious battle and feast on the boar Saehrimnir and mead from the goat Heidrún. The einherjar will fight alongside the gods at Ragnarok. This is preparation, not paradise.

FOLKVANGR — Freya's Field: Freya receives half of all who die in battle. Her realm, Folkvangr (People's Field), with her hall Sessrumnir, is where these honored dead reside. The heroic dead are divided between two divine patrons — honoring both the warrior nature (Odin) and the magical, loving nature (Freya) of the Norse divine world.

HELHEIM — The Realm of the Ordinary Dead: The majority of the Norse dead — those who died of illness, age, or non-battle circumstances — went to Helheim, the realm ruled by Hel. Despite the name's resemblance to the Christian Hell, Helheim is not a place of punishment. It is simply the destination of the ordinary dead: a grey, quiet realm where the dead exist in a dimmer version of their living state.

The Norse Soul — Multiple Components

Norse thought recognized multiple soul components, each with its own nature and post-death fate. The *hugr* (thought/mind) is the active thinking mind. The *fylgja* (follower/fetch) is a personal guardian spirit, often appearing as an animal, that accompanies a person through life and whose condition reflects their spiritual state. The *hamingja* is personal luck or spiritual power — a force that can be passed from the dying to the living and that accumulates or depletes based on the quality of one's life. The *líkr* (líkr) is the physical body. Understanding these components explains why the Norse treated their dead with such care — each component had specific needs and specific relationships to the surviving community.

What Is Paganism?

The Umbrella and Its Many Traditions

The word pagan (from the Latin *paganus* — rural dweller, villager) was used by early Christians as a term for those who continued to practice the old pre-Christian religions of Europe. Today paganism serves as a broad umbrella term for a diverse collection of nature-based, polytheistic, and pre-Christian or post-Christian spiritual traditions.

Despite the enormous diversity under the pagan umbrella, several orientations unite most pagan traditions: the recognition of nature as sacred (the living world as the primary expression of the divine); a polytheistic or at least pantheistic understanding of the divine (as many-faceted, encompassing both masculine and feminine principles); the honoring of seasonal cycles (the Wheel of the Year); ancestor veneration and the understanding of an ongoing relationship between the living and the dead; and an emphasis on direct experience of the sacred rather than on revealed scripture and institutional mediation.

ASATRU AND HEATHENRY: The reconstructionist Norse/Germanic traditions — attempting to practice authentic Norse paganism based on scholarship of the historical evidence. Iceland's Ásatrúarfélagið reported 6,023 members in 2025, representing 1.55% of the national population.

DRUIDRY: The Celtic nature spirituality tradition — explored in depth in the Druid deep dive.

HELLENISM: Practices the ancient Greek religion. Estimates suggest over 100,000 cultural sympathizers in Greece alone.

KEMETISM: Practices ancient Egyptian religion.

SLAVIC PAGANISM: Reconstructs the pre-Christian religious traditions of Eastern Europe.

WICCA: The most widespread modern pagan tradition — explored in depth below.

Wicca

History, Theology, and Practice

Wicca is the most widely practiced modern pagan religion — and one of the fastest-growing spiritual movements in the world. Popular culture has alternately demonized it as Satanism (it has no relation to Satan, who is a specifically Christian/Islamic theological figure) and trivialized it as a New Age hobby. Neither is accurate. Wicca is a genuine religion with a serious theology, a coherent ethical framework, a rich ritual practice, and a community of practitioners whose spiritual experiences deserve respect.

Origins: Gerald Gardner and the Birth of Modern Wicca

Modern Wicca was publicly inaugurated by Gerald Gardner (1884-1964), a British civil servant, anthropologist, and occultist who, following the repeal of Britain's Witchcraft Act in 1951, began publishing books about a witch religion he claimed to have encountered in the New Forest area of England in the late 1930s. His *Witchcraft Today* (1954) and *The Meaning of Witchcraft* (1959) introduced the public to what he called "the Craft" — a nature religion combining elements of ceremonial magic (from the Golden Dawn and from Aleister Crowley), folk magic traditions, and pre-Christian spiritual sensibility. Most contemporary Wiccan scholars — including many practitioners — acknowledge that Wicca as a formalized religion is substantially a twentieth-century creation, even if it draws on ancient materials. This does not invalidate its spiritual reality.

Doreen Valiente and the Heart of Wicca

If Gardner founded Wicca, Doreen Valiente (1922-1999) gave it its soul. Valiente was Gardner's High Priestess and the most gifted liturgical writer in the tradition's history. She identified the ceremonial magic elements Gardner had incorporated from Crowley (whose misogyny and baroque style she found inappropriate), rewrote them, and replaced them with poetry of genuine beauty and spiritual depth. *The Charge of the Goddess* — the central devotional text of Wicca, delivered by the High Priestess in the voice of the Goddess — is primarily her composition. Her *Witchcraft for Tomorrow* (1978) and other works established Wicca as a serious, thoughtful, feminine-honoring spiritual path.

Wiccan Ethics: The Rede and the Threefold Law

Wicca's primary ethical statement is the Wiccan Rede: "An it harm none, do what ye will." This is not a permission slip for unlimited self-indulgence — "harm none" is an extremely demanding standard that requires considering the consequences of one's actions for all beings affected. The Rede is a call to the exercise of genuine ethical discernment rather than the following of a fixed list of rules. The Threefold Law holds that whatever magical or intentional energy a practitioner sends into the world returns to them three times over — making harm-causing magic not merely ethically wrong but practically self-defeating.

The Wiccan Wheel of the Year and the Sabbats

The Wiccan sacred calendar follows the eight-spoked Wheel of the Year — the four solar festivals and four fire festivals inherited from Celtic and Germanic paganism. In Wicca, these eight celebrations are called Sabbats and are understood as the annual cycle of the sacred relationship between the God (solar principle, born at Yule, maturing through the year, dying at Samhain) and the Goddess (the earth, the Great Mother, whose fertility rises and falls with the seasons).

SAMHAIN (October 31): The most sacred of the Sabbats — the death of the Old Year, the thinning of the veil between the living and the dead, the beginning of the new year. The Wiccan New Year. Ancestor veneration is central.

YULE (Winter Solstice, c. December 21): The rebirth of the Sun God — the longest night, after which the light returns. The origin of most Christmas traditions (evergreen trees, candles, gifts, feasting).

IMBOLC (February 1-2): The first stirring of spring — Brigid's festival of the returning light. Candles lit throughout the house. The seed's first movement below the earth.

OSTARA (Spring Equinox, c. March 21): The balance point of spring — equal day and night. New beginnings, planting, the Goddess's fertility fully awakened. Origin of Easter's eggs and rabbits.

BELTANE (May 1): The peak of spring fertility — fire festivals, the sacred marriage of the God and Goddess, the time of love and abundance. May Day traditions.

LITHA / MIDSUMMER (Summer Solstice, c. June 21): The God at his peak power — the longest day. The turning point after which the light begins to wane.

LUGHNASADH / LAMMAS (August 1): The first harvest — the God's power beginning to decline as he gives his life to the grain. Gratitude, community, the first bread of the harvest.

MABON (Autumn Equinox, c. September 21): The second harvest — the balance point of autumn, equal day and night before the dark half of the year. Preparation for the descent into winter.

In addition to the Sabbats, Wicca observes the Esbats — ritual gatherings held at the full moon (and sometimes the new moon) that focus on magical working and the direct honoring of the Goddess in her lunar aspect.

Wiccan Deities

The God and the Goddess

The theological heart of Wicca is the divine couple — the God and the Goddess — who together constitute the complete divine reality. This is the recognition that the divine, in its complete expression, encompasses both the feminine creative principle and the masculine regenerative principle in a dynamic, sacred partnership.

The Goddess

The Goddess is the primary theological reality in most forms of Wicca. She is the Great Mother — the fertile earth, the dark ocean, the moon's changing phases, the womb that births all things and the tomb that receives them when they die. She is typically understood as triple: Maiden (youth, new beginnings, spring), Mother (fullness, creativity, summer), and Crone (wisdom, endings, winter) — corresponding to the three phases of the moon (waxing, full, waning) and the three phases of a woman's biological life. She has many names across different Wiccan traditions: Aradia, Diana, Hecate, Isis, Brigid, Cerridwen — she encompasses all goddesses while being identified with none of them exclusively.

The God

The God in Wicca is the solar/agricultural deity — born at Yule from the Goddess, growing in strength through spring, reaching his peak at Litha, beginning his decline through the harvest, and dying at Samhain to be reborn again at Yule. He is the Green Man (the spirit of plant life), the Horned God (depicted with antlers or horns — not the devil, whose horned imagery was itself derived from pre-Christian nature deity imagery), and the Lord of the Wild Hunt. He gives himself to the harvest so that his people may live — a solar divinity who is sacrificed for abundance.

Wiccan Ritual

Casting the Circle and the Elements

Wiccan ritual has a specific, structured form that creates a sacred container for magical and devotional work. The core elements are consistent across different traditions and solitary practitioners: the casting of the circle, the calling of the quarters, the invocation of the divine, the working, the cakes and ale (shared food and drink as sacrament), and the closing of the circle.

Casting the Circle

The ritual circle is the fundamental sacred space of Wiccan practice. It is cast (defined, energized, and bounded) by the High Priestess or Priest walking the circle's perimeter deosil (clockwise), typically with an athame (a ritual knife used for directing energy) or wand, while visualizing a sphere of white or blue light expanding from the center to encompass the working space. The circle is understood as existing simultaneously in the physical world and the astral/spiritual world — "between the worlds" — a temporary sacred space that concentrates magical energy and protects those within.

The Four Quarters and Elements

The four cardinal directions are called in sequence, each associated with a specific element, quality, and type of being. East is Air — intellect, communication, breath, new beginnings. South is Fire — will, transformation, passion, courage. West is Water — emotion, intuition, the unconscious, healing. North is Earth — physical manifestation, stability, abundance, the body. Together the four elements constitute the complete material reality in which magical work takes place.

The Charge of the Goddess and Drawing Down the Moon

Drawing Down the Moon is one of the most distinctive and powerful Wiccan ritual practices: the High Priest invokes the Goddess into the body and consciousness of the High Priestess, who then speaks the Charge of the Goddess in the first person, as the Goddess speaking directly to her people. This is not merely theatrical — it is a genuine invocatory practice in which the practitioner serves as a vessel for the divine presence to speak through. The Charge, as written by Doreen Valiente, includes the line: "If that which thou seekest thou findest not within thee, thou wilt never find it without thee."

Magic as Directed Natural Energy

Wiccan magic is understood as the practice of directing natural energy through intention, will, emotion, and symbolic action toward a specific outcome. Spell-working in Wicca uses candles, herbs, crystals, written intentions, visualization, chanting, and movement to concentrate and direct energy. The practitioner is not beseeching an external power to act — they are working with the energy that flows through them and through the natural world to catalyze change.

Where the Paths Cross

Norse, Pagan, Wicca, and Haligricity

The Norse/runic/Wiccan complex of traditions touches Haligricity at multiple, significant points — not as peripheral influences but as deep structural resonances.

THE RUNES AND THE LIVING SYMBOL: The runic system's understanding of each letter as a living force — not a representation of an idea but an actual concentration of a cosmic principle that can be engaged through inscription, chanting, and contemplation — is one of the world's most complete examples of the Haligric understanding of sacred symbol as genuine creative force.

ODIN AND THE COST OF WISDOM: Odin's willingness to pay enormous personal cost for wisdom — the eye, the hanging, the perpetual seeking — is one of the most honest ancient depictions of what genuine spiritual development actually costs. The seeker who approaches Haligricity wanting a comfortable system of spiritual affirmations has not yet met Odin.

THE WHEEL OF THE YEAR: The Wiccan/Norse/Celtic Wheel of the Year — the eight-gate sacred calendar — is structurally identical to the Haligric ritual calendar. The Words of Ignition for each gate are the Haligric expression of the same seasonal-energetic reality that the pagan traditions mapped and honored. Haligricity does not borrow the Wheel — it recognizes the Wheel as the actual pattern of living time that all traditions have independently perceived.

THE TRIPLE GODDESS AND THE DIVINE FEMININE: Wicca's triple Goddess — Maiden, Mother, Crone — is one of the most complete articulations of the divine feminine as encompassing the full spectrum of feminine power. Haligricity honors the divine feminine as equally fundamental to the divine masculine, and the triple Goddess framework gives language to the full range: the freshness and courage of the Maiden, the creative fullness of the Mother, and the deep wisdom of the Crone.

MAGIC AS CONSCIOUS DIRECTION OF NATURAL ENERGY: The Wiccan understanding of magic — as the deliberate direction of natural energy through intention, will, emotion, and symbolic action — is the most direct practical articulation of what Real Magic (Hali Sarah Parsons, 2015) introduces as its central subject. Magic is not supernatural — it is the natural operation of consciousness engaging with the living energy field that permeates all existence.

WYRD, FATE, AND THE LAW OF CAUSE AND EFFECT: The Norse Web of Wyrð — the understanding that the present field of possibilities is determined by all causes that have gone before, and that present choices are weaving the pattern of future consequences — is one of the most philosophically precise ancient expressions of the Law of Cause and Effect (the fifth Hermetic Principle). Every movement in the dimensions of experience is a thread being woven into the web that determines what comes next.

*"I know that I hung on the windswept tree for nine full nights,
wounded with a spear, and given to Odin — myself to myself —
on that tree of which no man knows from what roots it rises."*

— Havamal, The Sayings of the High One (Old Norse, c. 9th-10th century CE)

The Norse tradition asks the hardest question of any spiritual path: what are you willing to give up for wisdom? Not what affirmations are you willing to repeat, not what techniques are you willing to apply, but what are you willing to surrender — genuinely, permanently, at real cost — in order to know what must be known? Odin hung nine nights on the tree not because he had to but because he chose to. The runes screamed when he took them. Real knowledge is received that way. The Wiccan Charge of the Goddess whispers the same truth in softer tones: if you seek what you cannot find within yourself, you will never find it without. It is already here. It has always been here. The question is only what you are willing to sacrifice to stop looking elsewhere. Grand Rising.